

Chapter 102-1

If the system hadn't mentioned before that it was an existence that couldn't be known by others, Liang Shi would have thought Xu Qingzhu knew about the system.

While Liang Shi was spacing out, Xu Qingzhu asked, "The one you sang this morning."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You can sing it for them, but you can't sing it for me?" Xu Qingzhu's drowsy voice echoed in the room.

Liang Shi chuckled softly, her head naturally nuzzling against the ends of Xu Qingzhu's hair. "I can."

In the dim yellow space, their breaths intertwined.

Then slowly followed the rhythm of each other's breathing.

With a hint of caution, yet surrendering to this intimacy without barriers.

While Liang Shi was still thinking about where to start singing, Xu Qingzhu had already started singing directly.

"Da da da~..." Xu Qingzhu didn't know the lyrics, only remembering the melody. Her cool voice hummed it casually, but she could only hum one line before the next went off-key.

Liang Shi picked up the melody and sang, "Every day without being noticed, you appear silently, like a sunny day that suddenly warms me, like the eaves where I shelter from the pouring rain..."¹

Liang Shi's voice was gentle and soft, matching the atmosphere of this song perfectly.

Singing a cappella had its own charm.

Xu Qingzhu's fingers tapped lightly along with the melody of her singing, each tap falling on Liang Shi's forearm.

Liang Shi had barely slept the night before and had been running around all day. Now her voice grew lower and lower. When she reached the ending notes, she couldn't help but tighten her arms, holding Xu Qingzhu in her embrace through the blanket. Her slightly flushed face brushed against Xu Qingzhu's hair that carried a fresh orange fragrance, and she lowered her voice to say, "Xu Qingzhu, good night."

Xu Qingzhu had already fallen asleep.

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Early the next morning, Liang Shi woke to the sound of pattering rain.

Late autumn in this coastal city brought much rain, and it came unexpectedly. The sky was gloomy, and no sunlight could filter through the gaps in the curtains. It was actually perfect weather for sleeping.

Liang Shi slowly opened her eyes and met Xu Qingzhu's gaze.

Her eyes, having just woken up, were brighter than usual. Moreover, it looked like Xu Qingzhu had been awake for a while. She blinked at Liang Shi. "Morning."

Liang Shi had slept well—she hadn't even dreamed. Usually when sleeping alone in the second bedroom, with the weather cooling down recently and the blanket being a bit thin, she would always be woken up by the cold every morning. But tonight she felt warm all over and never felt cold.

Liang Shi looked at her and unconsciously smiled. "Good morning."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her. After a few seconds, Liang Shi couldn't help but ask, "What is it?"

"Don't move." Xu Qingzhu suddenly said.

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

A trace of confusion flashed in her eyes, but Xu Qingzhu reached out her hand toward her face.

Liang Shi hurriedly asked, "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu said seriously, "There's something on your face."

Liang Shi was puzzled. "What?"

Xu Qingzhu lightly pinched her face, holding back laughter as she said, "A bit of good looks."

Liang Shi: "....."

Her heart, which had suddenly risen to her throat, fell back to its original place. After a moment, she didn't know whether to laugh or cry, and said helplessly, "What kind of cheesy pickup line is this?"

"Sally told me last week." Xu Qingzhu said, "You can also take it as a bad joke."

In fact, when Sally had told it to Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu had rolled her eyes at her and asked very seriously, "Have you had too little work lately, so you're too idle?"

Sally was speechless and scolded her, "Blanche, you really don't understand romance."

Xu Qingzhu scoffed. "Tasteless cheesy pickup lines don't match your beautiful image."

Sally: "....."

But because this kind of thing was easy to remember and the timing was easy to control, even an extremely boring person saying it could produce unexpected results.

Xu Qingzhu had successfully tricked the just-awakened Liang Shi.

And Liang Shi returned the favor. "Teacher Xu, I have three sisters—one called East Eye, one called West Mouth, one called South Ear. What's my name?"²

Xu Qingzhu was silent for a moment. "Bei Bi?"³

Liang Shi: "....."

She had clearly guessed correctly, but Xu Qingzhu deliberately made the pronunciation sound strange.

Liang Shi's stock of cheesy pickup lines was limited, so these weren't really suitable for using with her.

Especially since they had just woken up, on the same bed, face to face and very close together. It was clearly an intimate distance, and it was the first time they had been in this situation, yet they were as familiar with each other as if they had been together for a long time.

Neither felt awkward.

Liang Shi shifted slightly to one side, not pressing so close to her.

But Xu Qingzhu suddenly grabbed her wrist. Liang Shi looked at her in surprise, their eyes meeting.

"Liang Shi." Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. When her cool voice called her name, it was tender. "Come closer."

Liang Shi moved over a bit.

"A little closer." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi moved over again.

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After two attempts, there was still more than ten centimeters between them. Xu Qingzhu simply moved forward herself, instantly falling into Liang Shi's embrace.

Liang Shi didn't know where to put her hands.

Xu Qingzhu's lips glistened like rippling water, as if covered in mist.

Seeing this, Liang Shi almost instinctively curled her fingers.

During sleep, Xu Qingzhu's nightgown had ridden up a bit. Then there was a simple emotional transition—Liang Shi just held Xu Qingzhu for a moment. There was nothing that couldn't be shown, and anyway, whether it could be shown or not, nothing could be seen.

After gazing at each other for a long time, it was Liang Shi who couldn't hold on and looked away first. But the moment she looked away, Xu Qingzhu pulled her back.

One of her hands rested on the side of Liang Shi's face, and then there was no further movement.

1. These are lyrics from the Chinese song "私奔到月球" (Erta to the Moon/Elope to the Moon) by Mayday featuring Cheer Chen. The song is a romantic duet about escaping together. ⇐
2. This is a Chinese wordplay pickup line. The directions East (东/Dōng), West (西/Xī), South (南/Nán) are paired with body parts Eye (眼/Yǎn), Mouth (嘴/Zuǐ), Ear (耳/Ěr). The missing direction is North (北/Běi), and the missing body part for "nose" is (鼻/Bí). Together they form "北鼻" (Běi Bí), which sounds like "baby" in English—a term of endearment. ⇐
3. Xu Qingzhu deliberately mispronounces "北鼻" (Běi Bí / "baby") as "卑鄙" (Bēi Bǐ), which means "despicable" or "contemptible" in Chinese, playfully deflecting the romantic intent of the pickup line. ⇐